

CORE FORMULA

You have [real basis]. What [small, concrete question] should I check first? -> You know this better than I do - what should I notice first? -> You have worked with these customers. What usually matters most? -> I have a tentative view, but you are closer to it. What would you challenge in my read? -> You are closest to the facts. What should we not miss before we act? -> Respectful close: "That helps - I had not separated those two issues."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one real domain where they have more context than you, then ask one small, answerable question: "You know this better than I do - what should I notice first?"

BEST FOR

- Meeting someone with a clear domain, craft, role, or lived experience
- Asking a colleague for local context before forming a view
- Networking without sounding transactional
- Learning taste, standards, trade-offs, or practical judgement
- Letting a junior person contribute safely by naming their proximity to the work
- Cross-cultural or technical contexts where guessing would be disrespectful
- Softening disagreement by first learning their read

PHRASE BANK

Social · Social & rapport

- "You know this world better than I do - what should I notice first?"
- "You have more reps with this than me. What is the part outsiders usually miss?"
- "I have not lived that, so I do not want to guess. How would you explain it?"
- "You have good taste in this area. What makes that one work?"
- "You have seen this from the inside. What is the real issue?"
- "You have been around this scene for years. Where would you start?"
- "You clearly care about this. What do most people get wrong about it?"

Professional · Work & meetings

- "You have been closer to this than I have. What would you look at first?"
- "You know this system better than me. What am I missing?"
- "You have the operator view here. What is the signal versus the noise?"
- "I trust your read on this domain. What should we be careful not to oversimplify?"
- "Before I form a view, I would like your take. What matters most here?"
- "You have the customer view here. What is the mood I may be missing?"
- "You have dealt with this kind of client before. What usually matters most?"

Narrow asks · Small, decision-owning asks

- "I will own the decision, but I need your read first. What is the strongest caution?"
- "What would you check before we decide?"
- "What is the one distinction beginners usually miss?"
- "I have a tentative view, but you are closer to it. What would you challenge in it?"
- "What is the risk I might be underweighting?"
- "You are closest to the handoff. What is the practical snag I may miss?"

- "What constraint should shape this decision?"

High-pressure · Pressure & live calls

- "You are closest to the facts. What is the safest first read?"
- "I do not want to make this abstract. From your view, what matters now?"
- "You have the ground-level read. What should we not miss?"
- "I can make the call, but I need your expertise first. What is your recommendation?"
- "Before we move, what would you flag from your side?"
- "You are closest to the data. What should we not miss before we act?"
- "We have to choose soon. From where you sit, what is the biggest risk?"

Quick forms & digital · One-liners & messages

- "What am I missing?"
- "What would you check first?"
- "What do outsiders miss?"
- "What is the hidden constraint?"
- "What would you not oversimplify?"
- "You know this area better than I do - what is the simplest way to think about it?"
- "Can I sanity-check this with you? What would an informed person see that I might miss?"

Credit the insight · Closing the loop

- "That helps - I had not separated those two issues."
- "Useful distinction. I was treating that as one problem."
- "That changes how I would approach it."
- "I had been looking at only one side of that."
- "I will factor that in - thank you for the steer."
- "That is the part I would have missed. Good catch."

Recovery · Repair & easy exits

- "I may have put you on the spot. You do not have to answer that."
- "Let me narrow that - I am only asking for the first thing you would check."
- "I did not mean to outsource the work to you. I am trying to understand your read."
- "That came out like flattery. I meant: you have useful context I do not have."
- "We can skip that if it is not easy to answer right now."
- "I will own the decision. I am asking for your read before I choose."
- "Only if you are comfortable answering - otherwise I should do my own homework first."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "You are the expert, so tell me what to do."
Better: "You know more about this than I do. What do you think?"
Best: "You have worked with this customer type for years. What would you check before we decide?"
- Weak: "Wow, you are a genius at this."
Better: "You have good judgement here."
Best: "Your read on these trade-offs is usually sharp. What is the risk I might be underweighting?"
- Weak: "Explain this whole field to me."
Better: "Can you explain the basics?"
Best: "What is the one distinction beginners usually miss?"
- Weak: "I do not know, you decide."
Better: "You probably know the better path."
Best: "I will own the decision, but I need your subject-matter read first. What is the strongest caution?"

DECISION TREE

If They have a real vantage point on this

Name it lightly and ask one narrow question.

"You know this better than I do - what should I notice first?"

If You cannot name the expertise specifically

Do not overclaim; hedge to "more context" rather than inventing a frame.

"You may have more context on this than I do. What stands out to you?"

If The question would take more than a minute to answer

Narrow it before you ask.

"Let me make that smaller - what is one thing I should check first?"

If They respond with energy

Listen, ask one follow-up, then credit the insight.

"That helps - I had not separated those two issues."

If They look burdened, unsure, or put on the spot

Give an easy exit and stop pushing.

"No pressure to answer that - I may be asking too much for this moment."

If You are still responsible for the decision or the work

Keep ownership; ask for their read, not their verdict.

"I will own the decision; I am asking for your read first."

SCENARIOS

A new colleague knows the system

Name their system history and ask what to grasp before you propose changes. — "You have the system history here.

What should I understand before I suggest changes?"

A friend has taste in a niche

Credit their eye and ask what makes their pick work, rather than handing them the whole choice. — "You have a good eye for this. What makes that place better than the others?"

A junior teammate is close to execution

Name their proximity privately, in a way that does not expose them politically. — "You are closest to the handoff. What is the practical snag I may miss?"

Cultural or identity context

Offer an easy exit first and ask about assumptions - never as a spokesperson for a group. — "Only if you are comfortable answering: is there an assumption here I should avoid?"

A technical expert in a meeting

Ask for the constraint that should shape the decision, not a live solution to a vague problem. — "You have the technical read. What constraint should shape the decision?"

Conflict with a specialist

Concede you may be oversimplifying and invite their correction instead of defending your read. — "I may be oversimplifying. From your side, what am I missing?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Their expertise is not actually relevant here
- They are rushed, overloaded, or already on the hook for too much
- The question asks for too much unpaid labour
- They have already said they do not want to explain
- Their status is low and your question could expose them politically
- The topic is private, traumatic, confidential, or identity-loaded
- You already know the answer and are asking theatrically

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the real basis

List five people you will speak with this week and name the one real slice of expertise, taste, or proximity each genuinely

has. No inventing - if there is no real basis, leave it blank.

Day 2 — Basis plus narrow question

Write five lines in the form "You have [basis]. What [small question]?" using different bases: experience, proximity, taste, technical knowledge, and local context.

Day 3 — Shrink the ask

Take three broad questions (e.g. "Explain this whole market") and rewrite each as one narrow, answerable version (e.g. "What is the one assumption beginners get wrong?").

Day 4 — Use it once for real

In one real conversation, name a real basis and ask a single narrow question. Notice whether they opened up, stayed neutral, or pulled back.

Day 5 — Credit the insight

Every time someone gives you a useful answer today, close the loop out loud: "That helps because...", "The useful distinction is...", or "I will factor that in by..."

Day 6 — Recovery reps

Practise the exits until they sound plain: "I may have put you on the spot", "Let me narrow that", "I will own the decision", "You do not have to answer that."

Day 7 — Full sequence under mild pressure

Run Notice -> Name -> Narrow -> Listen -> Credit in one higher-stakes conversation, keeping the decision yours. Log the green, yellow, or red cue you saw.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- What real expertise, experience, taste, or proximity did I actually notice?
- Did I name it specifically, or fall back on vague flattery?
- Was my question small enough to answer in under a minute?
- Did I give an easy exit if the topic was sensitive or labour-heavy?
- Did I listen without grabbing the status back?
- Did I credit the useful part and keep the decision mine?